SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #55 · WORK AND CALLING

# “God values me for what I accomplish.”

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## Where it often comes from

Children who are praised mostly for grades, achievements, or helpfulness often conclude that love is earned. In adulthood this becomes a quiet belief: God is pleased when I produce and disappointed when I do not. Church can reinforce it when service is applauded more than simple presence.

## What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast.” “He saved us, not by the righteous deeds we had done, but according to His mercy.” “God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.” When the disciples rejoiced in their success, Jesus said, “rejoice that your names are written in heaven.” Zephaniah says the LORD “will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love.” God’s delight in us is not a wage.

> *“For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast”* (Ephesians 2:8–9).

## Also see

> “He saved us, not by the righteous deeds we had done, but according to His mercy, through the washing of new birth and renewal by the Holy Spirit” (Titus 3:5).

> “But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us” (Romans 5:8).

> “Nevertheless, do not rejoice that the spirits submit to you, but rejoice that your names are written in heaven” (Luke 10:20).

> “The LORD your God is among you; He is mighty to save. He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love; He will rejoice over you with singing” (Zephaniah 3:17).

## Common self-statements

- God is pleased only when I achieve.
- I have to earn His approval.
- When I fail, He is disappointed.
- My worth goes up and down with my results.
- I must keep proving myself.
- I am loved for what I do.

## Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling worthless when I fail and concluding God sees me that way.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either accomplished and loved, or failing and unloved.
- Should statements: Insisting that I must earn God’s love.
- Mind reading: Assuming God is disappointed in me.

## Challenging questions

- When was I praised for what I did rather than who I was?

- What does “not by works” tell me about how God sees me?
- Did Christ die for me when I was productive or when I was a sinner?
- What does Zephaniah say God does over me?
- How would my days look different if I believed I was already loved?
- What would I do from love instead of for approval?

## Truth summary

> God values me because I am His, not because of what I accomplish. His love was given while I was still a sinner. I can work and serve from love, not for approval.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grace
- Love, By God
- Salvation
- Self-Esteem, Low
- God, All Loving

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love

## Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus’ love rather than personal strength.

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ’s final restoration.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

*Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "God values me for what I accomplish"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

"God values me for what I accomplish." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ When was I praised for what I did?
- ☐ What does "not by works" mean for me?
- ☐ How does God feel about me on a bad day?
- ☐ What does Zephaniah 3:17 say?
- ☐ What would I do from love?
- ☐ What can I do quietly for no reward?

My own question: _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ I am saved by grace, not works.
- ☐ God proved His love while I was a sinner.
- ☐ My name is written in heaven.
- ☐ He rejoices over me with singing.
- ☐ My worth does not rise and fall with results.
- ☐ I can serve from love.

In my own words: _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- ☐ Ephesians 2:8–9
  *"For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast."*
- ☐ Romans 5:8
  *"But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."*
- ☐ Zephaniah 3:17
  *"The LORD your God is among you; He is mighty to save. He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love; He will rejoice over you with singing."*

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Loved before doing: Each morning, say "I am loved before I do anything today," and note one task done from love.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  *For example, Ephesians 2:8–9 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am saved by grace, not by works, so God's love does not depend on what I accomplish.""*
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Grace" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

*This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.*

- [ ] Trace the message. Write who taught you that love is earned.
- [ ] Read Zephaniah 3:17. Imagine God singing over you, not tallying your day.
- [ ] Separate worth and work. Write one sentence that distinguishes who you are from what you do.
- [ ] Do one thing for no reward. Serve quietly, without anyone knowing.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "God values me for what I accomplish": _____ %  My truth: _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | Loved before doing |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

| Day | Song I listened to | What it told me that challenges the lie |
|---|---|---|
| Mon | | |
| Tue | | |
| Wed | | |
| Thu | | |
| Fri | | |
| Sat | | |
| Sun | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~God values me for what I accomplish.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Father, thank You for loving me before I did anything. Free me from trying to earn what You have already given. Help me work and serve from love, resting in Your delight in me. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*